THE RETAINER PRICING KIT / JOSH PEARSON

SAME CAMERA. SAME SKILL. £1K OR £10K.

The formula for pricing creative retainers, the ladder from £1k to £15k+ a month, a worksheet to price your next client, and how to say the number.

MY £1K RETAINERS PAY ME MORE PER HOUR THAN MY £10K ONE DID.

£1K **£1,000 a month, three years running.** 6 to 7 hours a month. About £150 an hour, and nearly £30,000 from one client so far.

£1K **£1,000 a month, right now.** About 6 hours a month. Around £165 an hour.

£10K **£10,000 a month.** A team of two, 2 to 3 days a week. £96 to £125 an hour before paying the second person. Less after.

The £10k retainer looked like the win. Per hour, it was the worst of the three, and it took most of my week. The £1k retainers are small, quick, and they've lasted years.

That's why this kit doesn't just push you to charge more. It shows you what each hour actually pays, so you can choose your route: fewer, bigger clients, or more small ones that run without eating your life.

YOU WIN ON EXPERTISE × LEVERAGE

HIGH EXPERTISE / LOW LEVERAGE **BUSY EXPERT** Good money, capped by your hours.	HIGH EXPERTISE / HIGH LEVERAGE **THE DEPT.** Own the result. Agents carry the work.
LOW EXPERTISE / LOW LEVERAGE **SERVICE PROVIDER** The hired tripod. Paid for hours.	LOW EXPERTISE / HIGH LEVERAGE **CONTENT FACTORY** Volume without authority. A commodity.

I've sold social retainers for £1,000 a month and social retainers for £10,000 a month. I've done full-service retainers at about £15,000 a month. The camera didn't change. What changed was who I was selling to, what I was promising, what it cost me to make, and what I decided I wanted to earn.

Most creatives price from the bottom up: what other people charge, what they charged last time, what feels safe to say. That's how you end up at £500 shoots forever. Price comes from four questions, in this order.

To be straight with you: this isn't about everyone charging £10k a month. You can make very good money on £1,500 retainers. What matters is what each one pays you for the time it takes, and how many you can run without burning out. It all comes down to one thing: time in, money out. Know your numbers, then pick your route.

01 **Who is the client?** A local café and a brand doing £5m a year can buy the same video. One of them can afford to pay you properly for it, and gets far more value from it. Who you sell to sets your ceiling more than anything else.

02 **What's the brief, really?** "Four videos a month" is the deliverable. The brief is the result they want: attention, leads, sales, a launch that lands. The closer you get to owning the result, the more the work is worth.

03 **What does it cost to make?** Your hours, your crew, your kit, your travel. Solo or team changes your price more than your camera ever will. This is your floor. Never go under it.

04 **What do you want to make?** Not what you think they'll pay. What the work needs to earn you for your business to be worth running. Decide it before the call, not during.

Questions three and four give you the floor. Questions one and two tell you how far above the floor you can go. That gap is where the money is, and it's where most people leave it on the table.

CLIMB BY CHANGING WHO YOU SELL TO.

LEVEL 01

£1k

Content support. Solo. A small business. A handful of edits a month, often from footage they send you. Great money if it takes you a day or two and you run several. A trap if it eats your week.

LEVEL 02

£3k

Content partner. A shoot day a month, a set number of edits, a plan for what goes out. You're making decisions now, not just taking instructions.

LEVEL 03

£5-10k

Growth partner. A brand with real budget. Strategy, production and reporting against the result they care about. Often an editor or second shooter under you.

LEVEL 04

£15k+

Full service. You own the outcome across content, campaigns and launches, with a team doing the making. You're the expert they can't replace.

Every level is a step on the same ladder: more ownership of the result, a bigger client, and less of your own hours per pound. You don't have to climb to the top to do well. Plenty of people make a great living at level two with five or six clients and an editor. If you want to climb, you do it by changing who you sell to and how you sell, not by getting better at filming.

WHERE ARE YOU NOW? WHERE'S YOUR NEXT CLIENT? CIRCLE BOTH.

THE HONEST PART

The bigger money, generally, is in owning a result: more customers, a launch that sells, a brand that grows. That takes a stack of skills: strategy, production, editing, copy, ads, reporting. It used to mean a team. My £10k retainer needed two people and most of my week. Now AI does a lot of what that second person did. One creative with the right agents can own a result that used to need an agency. Own more of the result, without adding more of your hours.

RUN THE NUMBERS.

Prefer it done for you? The calculator at lockedindept.com/pricing-kit/kit does this as you type.

Who is the client? Business, size, what a new customer is worth to them

What are they really buying? The result, in their words

Shoot days a month × 10 hours	
Edits a month × hours per edit	
Strategy, calls and admin hours	
Total hours ÷ 8 = days	
Days × your day rate	
+ Crew and freelancers a month	
+ Kit, software and travel a month	
YOUR FLOOR	_____
× Who: 1.0 small local / 1.4 growing brand / 2.0 established brand	
× Brief: 1.0 content / 1.25 leads or sales / 1.5 you own the growth	
YOUR PRICE, A MONTH	_____
Time in, money out: (price – crew – kit) ÷ total hours = £ an hour	
A: lighter version (price × 0.6)	
B: the one you want them to pick (your price)	
C: more output, more ownership (price × 1.7)	

PRESCRIBE. DON'T QUOTE.

DIAGNOSE BEFORE YOU PRESCRIBE

Don't send a price list. Ask about the business first: what they sell, what a new customer is worth, what's not working. A doctor doesn't hand you a menu. When the price comes after you've understood the problem, it lands as a prescription, not a cost.

THREE QUESTIONS FOR THE CALL

01 What are you selling, and what's a new customer worth to you?

02 What's working right now, and what isn't?

03 If this went perfectly, what would be different in 90 days?

ALWAYS THREE OPTIONS

Give them A, B and C. B is the one you want. C makes B look sensible. A is there so the answer is "which one", not "yes or no".

SAY IT, THEN STOP

Say the number out loud and stop talking. No "but we can be flexible". No explaining. The silence feels long to you and normal to them. If the number makes you nervous, that's usually the sign it's right.

MONTHLY, NOT PER PROJECT

Project work keeps you on the hamster wheel: win, deliver, start again from zero. Retainers give you a floor every month and a client relationship that grows. Fewer clients, paying more, every month.

THE NUMBER IS THE EASY PART.

Believing it, saying it and getting the right clients in front of you is the work. That's what the 90 days are for: ten creatives, from January. We fix the offer, the price and the pitch, and we work on the person who has to say the number.

It comes with an ROI guarantee. Do the work, and if you haven't made back what you paid by day 90, Josh keeps working with you free until you have.

APPLY AT LOCKEDINDEPT.COM/90-DAYS